DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Happens After the Year Seven Thousand?

Daat Tevunot §93-94

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §93-94 (end of section 4), with a review of the five levels **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 20 February 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: three times, five levels

We are at §93, page 220 in the English, at the end of section 4. The Rabbi reviewed the last class. In general there are three times: this world (up to six thousand), the seventh millennium (six to seven thousand), and from seven thousand onwards, the renewed world. More precisely there are five levels, and in all of them the body is present, because the body that worked must receive reward:

1. The soul in complete control, the body completely submissive, with no opinion of its own.
2. The same, but with vague, general recollections of the past.
3. The same, but with more specific recollections.
4. The body submissive, but not intrinsically. At its core it still wants to be a body, but it is "under the spell" of the soul, like Moshe on the mountain, a guest who keeps quiet and follows the custom of the place.
5. The body in control. In 5B a person lets the body run wild; in 5A the body does what it needs, but for higher purposes.

Fitting the levels to time

The Rabbi then set the levels on the timeline, noting that the Ramhal only implies this and does not spell it out.

- **Up to six thousand: level five.** The body is in control and the soul must combat it. It is our choice whether to be 5A or 5B.
- **Six to seven thousand: level four.** This is the meaning of Hazal's statement that the righteous float above the water. The resurrection has taken place, and body and soul are reunited, but the body has not yet been renewed, because that renewal goes hand in hand with the renewal of the world, which begins only at seven thousand.
- **Seven to ten thousand: levels three, two and one.** As the verse says, "they go from strength to strength". The refinement does not happen in a moment; it is a process. The Rabbi said the Kabbalists divide this period into three: from seven to eight thousand the body is intrinsically changed but a weariness remains, with specific memories of the

physical past holding the soul back from fully experiencing the Divine (level three); from eight to nine thousand only vague, general memories remain (level two); from nine to ten thousand one approaches level one, and by ten thousand the soul is in complete control and the body completely submissive. "This is the beauty of the Ramhal. He gives you all the Kabbalistic ideas, he doesn't actually tell you them."

Who is "you"?

A participant mentioned a teaching he had heard on Shabbat: between the body and the Neshamah there is a connector, the nefesh. The Rabbi said this fits the question Mark had raised in recent weeks: if the soul is perfect and the body is not, who are you? The answer is the nefesh, the lowest of the five levels of the Neshamah. This is not the nefesh habehemit, which only gives life to the flesh, as in every animal. It is the human level of consciousness that decides whether to follow the Neshamah or the body. "So you see how these five levels all come together. Isn't it beautiful."

Questions about the timeline

Where are the righteous between six and seven thousand? "I can't tell you, I've got no idea." Just as we do not know where Moshe was for forty days and nights. "These things we'll have to wait and experience."

Will there be new souls after six thousand? No. The six thousand years are the time of work. After that there is no more work and no new souls.

When is the world of souls? Now. Anyone who dies during the six thousand years goes there; a person may spend up to twelve months in Gehinnom, then Gan Eden, waiting to be reunited with the body. The resurrection takes place around the end of the six thousand years, for everyone together.

What comes after ten thousand? The Rabbi said that in the Kabbalah the end corresponds to keter, the highest of the sefirot, when the whole process is complete. Asked whether worlds renew in cycles, he mentioned the Midrash that God built worlds and destroyed them before this one, and a Kabbalistic view that ours is the last of seven cycles. He stressed the difference in status: the six thousand years, the seventh millennium and the righteous given wings are in the Gemara and must be accepted; the Kabbalistic cycles are something "some say", and "whether you believe it or not, it's your prerogative".

A digression: yesod and Shovavim

The Rabbi explained that in the Kabbalah the number six corresponds to yesod, the sefirah associated with sexual matters and their rectification. We are in the sixth millennium, so this is considered the great challenge of our time. That is the root of the custom of Shovavim, the six weeks of the parashot from Shemot to Mishpatim, which the Kabbalists treat as an especially powerful time for repentance for sexual sins. He described what he has seen in Israel: Thursdays kept as fast days in Kabbalistic circles, Tehillim recited several times in one day, and pidyon nefesh, where a person gives money in place of fasts. He noted that the custom comes from the Arizal and was taken up most by Hasidim.

§93-94: what we cannot know

The Neshamah says: from seven thousand onwards, all of this is hidden from our knowledge. How can we speak of it? The Sekhel agrees: we will not speak of it. That, the Rabbi said, is why the Ramhal does not lay out the stages from seven to ten thousand, which appear only in the Kabbalah. What we can know in detail is the present time, and that is what the next section will discuss. Of the other times we know only the general idea: from six thousand onwards the body loses its control and the soul is restored to its original power.

Next: how could a good God create evil?

The next section, the Rabbi said, is very important. It asks how a good God could create evil, and "it's not so simple". Before it, he asked everyone to revise the summary of section 4 (pages 224-230) and, briefly, the English summaries of sections 1-3, because the next part cannot be understood without all four sections clear.

Summary

- The five levels map onto time: level five until six thousand, level four from six to seven thousand, and levels three, two and one from seven to ten thousand.
- Refinement after the resurrection is gradual, "from strength to strength", and complete only at ten thousand.
- The "you" that chooses between body and soul is the nefesh, the lowest level of the Neshamah.
- The Gemara's timeline must be accepted; further Kabbalistic details, such as cycles of worlds, are more speculative.
- §93-94 close section 4: what lies beyond seven thousand is hidden, and the next section turns to the origin of evil.

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